

PARIKSHA365 — STUDY NOTES

Vocabulary — Cluster-Based Book

All exams — Roots, Suffixes, Confusables, OWS,
Idioms, Foreign phrases

SSC

RRB

BANKS

STATE PSC

v 2026-04

The promise. Read this book end-to-end (with the usual two re-reads + active recall on the embedded prompts) and you will be able to attempt every quiz question in the Pariksha365 pool for this subject with a strong fundamental grasp.

EXAM ALERT**Examiner Blueprint — Vocabulary****Top 8 most-tested vocabulary areas (question share across SSC + Banks):**

Rank	Area	SSC CGL T - 1	IBPS PO Pre	IBPS PO Mains
1	Synonyms	3–5	3–5	3–5
2	Antonyms	3–5	2–4	2–4
3	Idioms & Phrases (meaning + usage)	3–5	2–3	3–5
4	One - word Substitution	3–5	1–2	2–3
5	Fill in the Blanks (confusable pairs)	3–5	3–5	3–5
6	Cloze Test (vocabulary in context)	2–3	5–10	5–10
7	Spelling (identify correctly spelled word)	2–3	0–1	0–1
8	Suffix definitions (–phobia, –cide, –cracy, –ology)	1–2	0–1	1–2

KEY FACT**Study Priority Order** (return-on-study-time, highest first)

1. **Root families** — 50 high-yield roots unlock 2,000+ words. Start here; it is the highest-return vocabulary habit — one root unlocks a family of words.
2. **Confusable pairs** — affect/effect, principal/principle, eminent/imminent, etc. These appear across synonyms, fill-in-the-blanks, and cloze tests simultaneously.
3. **Idioms & Phrases** — 200 PYQ-weighted idioms cover virtually every question in this category across SSC, Banks, and RRB.
4. **One-word Substitution** — 150 high-frequency set; examiners recycle the same 80 words heavily across papers.
5. **Suffix clusters** (–phobia, –cide, –cracy, –ology) — 30 minutes per cluster locks in direct definition questions permanently.
6. **Synonyms & Antonyms** — drill from the PYQ-weighted word list in Part B onward; focus on words that have appeared at least twice across papers.
7. **Spelling** — 1 hour on the 60 most commonly misspelled exam words; reliably clears this sub-section.
8. **Cloze Test** — reading-pace + vocabulary-in-context; improves naturally as the rest of the vocabulary builds.

How to use this book

Vocabulary is the lowest-ROI-when-done-wrong, highest-ROI-when-done-right section of any English paper.

- **Done wrong** — alphabetical lists of 5,000 words you'll forget by next week.
- **Done right** — 1,500–2,000 **high-hit words** grouped into **root / suffix / theme clusters** that the brain learns 10-at-a-time through a shared hook.

Two rules this book is built on:

1. **Every word earns its place.** Included only if it has **appeared in PYQs** of SSC / Banking / RRB / PSU / State PSCs, OR if a seasoned paper-setter would pick it as a trap (subtle nuance, confusable, teachable root). No filler. No obscure dictionary-flex words.
2. **Learn by cluster, not by letter.** Ten **-phobia** words together is easier than ten random A-words. One root (**spect-**) unlocks 12 words. One confusable pair (**principal** vs **principle**) lasts forever once laughed at.

For each cluster / word, you get:

- **Cluster key** — the root / suffix / theme (e.g., *-cide = killing of*).
- **Memory hook** — etymology or visual/sound association that makes recall automatic.
- **Meaning** in one line.
- **Example sentence** in exam register.
- **Close synonyms & antonyms** (only ones that actually appear in exams).
- **Typical exam framing** — how examiners usually test this word.

How each cluster is structured

- **Cluster tree** — a diagram for each root family shows all derived words at a glance.
- **Revise on Day 1, Day 3, Day 7** — three short revisits per cluster beat one long session.
- **Say it aloud** after every cluster — use each word in a sentence before moving on.
- **Rapid-fire prompts** — at the end of each part, match-the-meaning drills force active recall.
- **Roots mixed with themes** — prevents list-fatigue and trains you to guess unfamiliar words.
- **Paper-setter's trap** — every cluster ends with the distractor-twin pairs the examiner loves (**affect** / **effect**, **eminent** / **imminent** / **immanent**).

How to read this book — your real study load

Total pages: 40.

This is a specialised exam-prep book. **Every page is essential** — including the worked-example drills, mini-mock and trap-cards near the end. Skipping any section costs you marks.

Read end-to-end in order without skipping.

Index — Table of Contents (clickable)

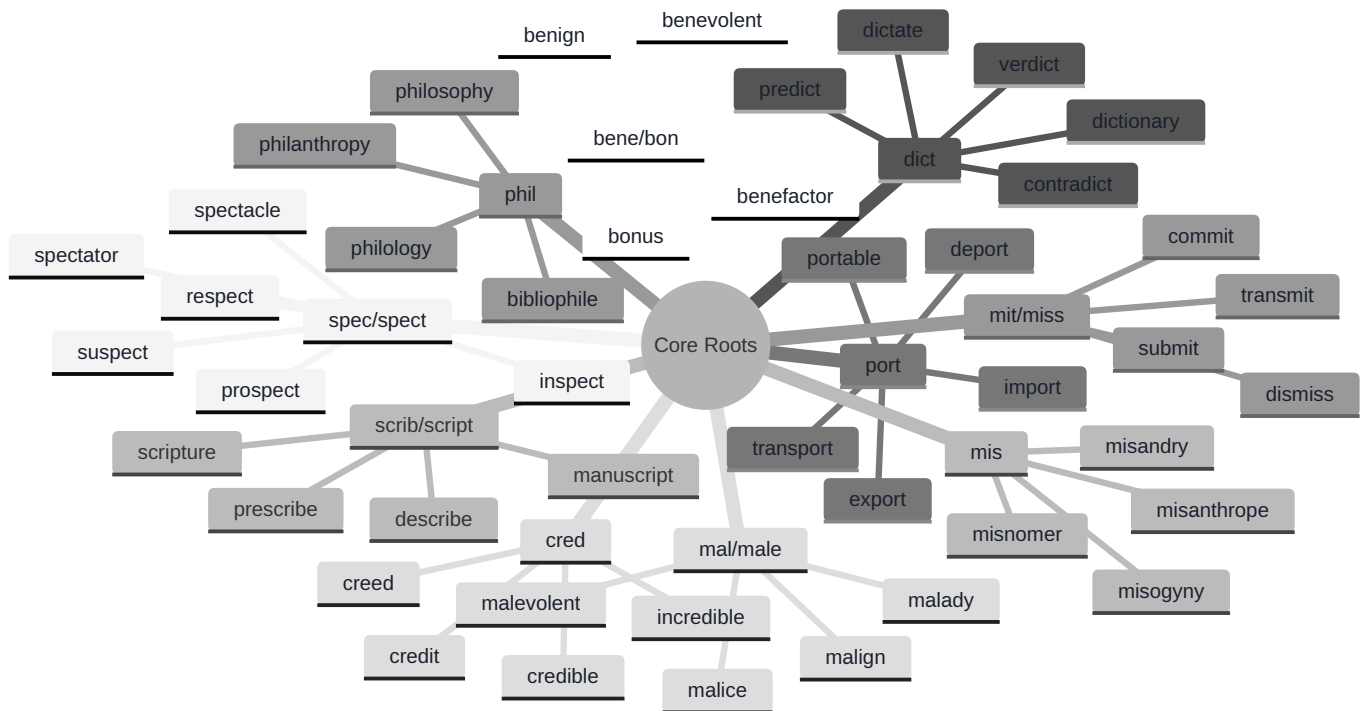
Pages	Part / Chapter	Topic / What it covers
p4–11	PART A	ROOTS, PREFIXES, SUFFIXES (the force multipliers)
p12	PART D	CLUSTER 3: -CIDE (killing of X)
p13	PART E	CLUSTER 4: -CRACY (rule by)
p14	PART F	CLUSTER 5: -LOGY (the study of X)
p15	PART G	CLUSTER 6: -PHILE / -PHOBE (lovers and haters)
p16	PART H	CONFUSABLES (the one-letter traps)
p17–21	PART I	HIGH-HIT SYNONYMS (examiners' favourite 100)
p22–24	PART J	ONE-WORD SUBSTITUTIONS (by semantic field)
p25–26	PART K	IDIOMS (the high-hit 50)
p27–29	PART L	FOREIGN PHRASES
p30–40	PART X	230 ADDITIONAL HIGH-FREQUENCY WORDS (themed clusters)

PART A — ROOTS, PREFIXES, SUFFIXES (the force multipliers)

Why start here:

- If you know **50 high-yield roots + 30 prefixes + 20 suffixes**, you can decode **~2,000 English words** you have never seen before.
- One root → a whole family of words.

A.1 The 50 high-yield ROOTS



Top-25 roots (drill first):

Root	Meaning	Sample high - hit words
spec / spect	to see	inspect, respect, suspect, prospect, spectacle
dict	to say	dictate, predict, contradict, verdict, edict
scrib / script	to write	describe, prescribe, scripture, manuscript, inscribe
port	to carry	import, export, transport, portable, deport
mit / miss	to send	transmit, submit, dismiss, omit, remit
cred	to believe	credible, credit, credulous, creed, incredible
bene / bon	good	benevolent, benefactor, benign, bonus, benediction
mal / male	bad	malice, malign, malevolent, malady, maladroit
mis	hate	misanthrope (hater of mankind), misogyny (of women), misandry (of men)
phil	love	philosophy, philanthropy, philology, bibliophile
chron	time	chronology, chronic, anachronism, synchronous
graph / gram	written	biography, autograph, grammar, telegram
log / logy	word, study	dialogue, monologue, biology, ecology
path	feeling, disease	empathy, apathy, antipathy, pathology
phon	sound	phonetics, symphony, cacophony, euphony

Root	Meaning	Sample high - hit words
cide	to kill	homicide, genocide, suicide, patricide
arch	rule, chief	monarchy, anarchy, matriarch, archbishop
cracy	rule by	democracy, autocracy, plutocracy, theocracy
therm	heat	thermal, thermometer, hypothermia, isotherm
hydr	water	hydrate, hydraulic, hydrophobia, dehydrate
geo	earth	geography, geology, geometry, geocentric
bio	life	biology, biography, antibiotic, symbiosis
demo	people	democracy, demographic, pandemic, epidemic
poly	many	polygon, polyglot, polygamy, polytheism
mono	one	monotony, monarch, monopoly, monotheism

Top prefixes

Prefix	Meaning	Samples
a -/an -	not, without	amoral, apathy, anarchy, anonymous
ab -	away from	abduct, abrupt, abnormal, abstain
ad -	toward	adhere, adjoin, adopt, adapt
ante -	before	antecedent, antedate, anteroom
anti -	against	antidote, antonym, antipathy, antibiotic
auto -	self	autograph, automatic, autonomy, autopsy
bi -	two	bicycle, bilingual, biennial, bipartisan
circum -	around	circumnavigate, circumference, circumspect
contra -/counter -	against	contradict, contravene, counterpoint
de -	down, away	descend, degrade, deport, derail
dis -	not, apart	disagree, disperse, dismiss, distract
ex -	out	exit, exclude, export, extract
extra -	beyond	extraordinary, extracurricular, extrapolate
hyper -	over, excessive	hypertension, hyperactive, hyperbole
hypo -	under	hypothesis, hypothermia, hypodermic
inter -	between	intercede, international, interrupt
intra -	within	intravenous, intramural, intranet

Prefix	Meaning	Samples
multi -	many	multimedia, multilingual, multitude
omni -	all	omnipotent, omniscient, omnipresent, omnivore
peri -	around	perimeter, periscope, peripheral
post -	after	postscript, postpone, posthumous
pre -	before	precede, predict, prefix, preview
pro -	forward	progress, proceed, project, promote
re -	again	rebuild, return, replay, recover
sub -	under	submarine, subordinate, submerge, subvert
super -	over	supervise, superior, supernatural, supersede
trans -	across	transmit, transport, translate, transcend
un -	not	uncommon, unable, unhappy, uninterested
uni -	one	unicorn, uniform, unilateral, unison

Top suffixes (and the GRAMMAR they imply)

Suffix	Part of speech	Meaning	Samples
-able/-ible	adj	capable of	readable, audible, visible, edible
-al	adj/noun	related to	natural, legal, approval, arrival
-ance/-ence	noun	state of	resistance, independence, silence, ignorance
-ary	adj/noun	related to	contrary, revolutionary, military
-cide	noun	killing	homicide, genocide, suicide
-cracy	noun	rule by	democracy, autocracy
-dom	noun	state, domain	freedom, kingdom, wisdom
-er/-or	noun	one who	teacher, actor, creator
-ful	adj	full of	beautiful, careful, useful
-hood	noun	state of	childhood, neighbourhood
-ic/-ical	adj	related to	magic, historical, philosophical
-ism	noun	doctrine	capitalism, socialism, terrorism
-ist	noun	practitioner	artist, pianist, scientist
-ity/-ty	noun	state of	unity, reality, cruelty
-ive	adj	tending to	active, creative, productive

Suffix	Part of speech	Meaning	Samples
-less	adj	without	careless, hopeless, useless
-logy	noun	study of	biology, geology
-ly	adv	manner	quickly, slowly, easily
-ment	noun	result of	payment, development, agreement
-ness	noun	state of	kindness, sadness, darkness
-ous	adj	full of	dangerous, famous, courageous
-phobia	noun	fear of	claustrophobia, xenophobia
-phile	noun	lover of	bibliophile, oenophile
-ship	noun	state, skill	friendship, leadership, craftsmanship

KEY FACT

✂ **SAY THE ROOT OUT LOUD** — After learning each Latin/Greek root, say the root and a derived word aloud three times. Your auditory memory retains sounds far better than visual lists. "*spect* — *inspect*, *spect* — *inspect*, *spect* — *inspect*." One minute per root = permanent recall. This single habit separates students who forget roots by exam day from those who decode unfamiliar words cold.

Feynman check: Using only the tables above, decode: *omniscient, anachronism, benefactor, misanthrope, xenophobic, subterranean, autocracy, philanthropist, gerontocracy, matricide*. All ten should fall out.

PART B — CLUSTER 1: PHOBIAS (**-phobia** = fear of X)

Memory hook: Greek **phobos** = fear / dread. Attach the Greek root of the feared thing to **-phobia**.

Revision slots: Day 1, Day 3, Day 7.

Word	Fear of	Hook / Etymology
Acrophobia	heights	Gk. <i>akron</i> = peak (Acropolis = high city)
Agoraphobia	open spaces	Gk. <i>agora</i> = marketplace
Aichmophobia	sharp objects, needles	Gk. <i>aichme</i> = spear point
Ailurophobia	cats	Gk. <i>ailuros</i> = cat
Algophobia	pain	Gk. <i>algos</i> = pain (analgesic = pain-killer)
Androphobia	men	Gk. <i>andros</i> = man
Arachnophobia	spiders	Gk. <i>arachne</i> = spider
Astraphobia	lightning, thunder	Gk. <i>astrape</i> = lightning
Autophobia	being alone	Gk. <i>autos</i> = self
Bibliophobia	books	Gk. <i>biblion</i> = book (compare bibliophile = lover)
Claustrophobia	closed/confined spaces	L. <i>claustrum</i> = enclosed place
Cynophobia	dogs	Gk. <i>kynos</i> = dog (also "cynical" — snarling philosophers)
Demophobia / Ochlophobia	crowds	Gk. <i>demos</i> = people / <i>ochlos</i> = mob
Entomophobia	insects	Gk. <i>entomon</i> = insect (entomology = study of insects)
Gamophobia	marriage	Gk. <i>gamos</i> = marriage (polygamy)
Glossophobia	public speaking	Gk. <i>glossa</i> = tongue (glossary = list of tongues)
Gynophobia	women	Gk. <i>gyne</i> = woman (misogyny)
Haemophobia / Hemophobia	blood	Gk. <i>haima</i> = blood (haemoglobin)
Hippophobia	horses	Gk. <i>hippos</i> = horse (hippopotamus = river horse)
Hydrophobia	water (also rabies symptom)	Gk. <i>hydor</i> = water
Hypnophobia	sleep	Gk. <i>hypnos</i> = sleep
Necrophobia	death, corpses	Gk. <i>nekros</i> = corpse

Word	Fear of	Hook / Etymology
Nyctophobia / Achluophobia	darkness / night	Gk. <i>nyx</i> = night
Ophidiophobia	snakes	Gk. <i>ophis</i> = snake
Ornithophobia	birds	Gk. <i>ornis</i> = bird (ornithology)
Photophobia	light	Gk. <i>phos</i> = light
Pyrophobia	fire	Gk. <i>pyr</i> = fire (pyre, pyrotechnic)
Thanatophobia	death	Gk. <i>thanatos</i> = death (euthanasia = good death)
Triskaidekaphobia	the number 13	Gk. <i>treis-kai-deka</i> = three and ten
Xenophobia	foreigners, strangers	Gk. <i>xenos</i> = stranger
Zoophobia	animals	Gk. <i>zoon</i> = animal (zoology)

KEY FACT

Mnemonic — phobia cluster: Remember the FIVE most-confused phobias with this image: "**A Crazy Glossy Xeno Hydra**" = **A**crophobia (heights) · **C**laustrophobia (closed spaces) · **G**lossophobia (public speaking) · **X**enophobia (strangers) · **H**ydrophobia (water/rabies). These five appear in at least one paper per year.

Paper-setter's traps in this cluster:

- *Hydrophobia* has TWO meanings: (i) fear of water, (ii) a symptom of rabies where the patient avoids water. Both are tested.
- *Xenophobia* vs *xenophile* — hater vs lover of foreigners. Antonym pairs appear frequently — examiners treat them as a reliable trap.
- *Claustrophobia* vs *agoraphobia* — confined vs open. Opposite pair, same fear engine.

Retrieval check: Without looking back, give the meaning of: *triskaidekaphobia*, *ailurophobia*, *glossophobia*, *ophidiophobia*, *thanatophobia*.

PART C — CLUSTER 2: MANIAS (**-mania** = obsession, frenzy)

Memory hook: Gk. *mania* = madness. Same root-formula as **-phobia** .

Word	Obsession with	Hook
Kleptomania	stealing	Gk. <i>klepto</i> = to steal
Pyromania	fire - setting	Gk. <i>pyr</i> = fire (pair with pyrophobia)
Megalomania	power, grandeur	Gk. <i>megas</i> = great
Bibliomania	collecting books	<i>biblion</i> = book
Dipsomania	drinking alcohol	Gk. <i>dipsa</i> = thirst
Monomania	a single idea	<i>monos</i> = one
Nymphomania	excessive sexual desire (female)	medical / clinical
Egomania	obsession with self	L. <i>ego</i> = I
Dromomania	wandering, travel	Gk. <i>dromos</i> = running
Graphomania	writing	<i>graph</i> = write
Plutomania	wealth	Gk. <i>ploutos</i> = wealth
Trichotillomania	pulling out one's own hair	rare but tested

PART D — CLUSTER 3: -cide (killing of X)

Memory hook: L. *caedere* = to kill, cut down. Every -cide word is a kind of killing.

Word	Killing of
Homicide	a human being (general)
Suicide	oneself
Patricide	one's father
Matricide	one's mother
Fratricide	one's brother
Sororicide	one's sister
Filicide	one's child
Infanticide	an infant
Regicide	a king / monarch
Genocide	a whole race / ethnic group
Uxoricide	one's wife
Mariticide	one's husband
Deicide	a god
Pesticide	pests (insects)
Herbicide	plants / weeds
Fungicide	fungi
Ecocide	the environment
Tyrannicide	a tyrant

KEY FACT

Mnemonic — -cide cluster: Picture a family dinner gone wrong: "**Patricide** → **father (paternal)**, **Matricide** → **mother (maternal)**, **Fratricide** → **brother (fraternal)**" — the Latin family-relation word always hides at the front. For regicide vs tyrannicide: a KING is a *rex* (Latin), a TYRANT is *tyrannos* (Greek) — the word origin matches the culture that hated tyrants most (Greece).

Paper-setter's favourite pairings:

- *matricide* vs *patricide* — quick sex-test.
- *genocide* vs *homicide* — scale-test (one vs many).
- *regicide* vs *tyrannicide* — moral framing-test (king vs tyrant).

Retrieval check: killing of brother = ? ; killing of one's wife = ? ; killing of a god = ?

PART E — CLUSTER 4: -CRACY (rule by)

Memory hook: Gk. *kratos* = power, rule.

Word	Rule by
Democracy	the people (Gk. <i>demos</i>)
Autocracy	one self-appointed (Gk. <i>autos</i>)
Monarchy	one (Gk. <i>monos</i> + <i>archein</i> = to rule)
Aristocracy	the best / noble-born (Gk. <i>aristos</i>)
Plutocracy	the wealthy (Gk. <i>ploutos</i>)
Theocracy	gods / religion (Gk. <i>theos</i>)
Meritocracy	the meritorious
Technocracy	technical experts
Bureaucracy	officials (Fr. <i>bureau</i> = desk)
Gerontocracy	the elderly (Gk. <i>geron</i>)
Kakistocracy	the worst citizens (Gk. <i>kakistos</i> = worst)
Kleptocracy	thieves (overlap with kleptomania root)
Oligarchy	a few (Gk. <i>oligos</i>) — note -archy not -cracy
Patriarchy	fathers / men
Matriarchy	mothers / women
Anarchy	no one — absence of rule

KEY FACT

Mnemonic — -cracy cluster: "Demos rules = Democracy; Autos (self) rules = Autocracy; Ploutos (wealth) rules = Plutocracy; Kakistos (worst) rules = Kakistocracy." Remember: the root always tells you WHO rules. When you see an unfamiliar -cracy word in an MCQ, decode the root before looking at options — the answer is already in the word.

Compare & contrast: *democracy* (all people), *ochlocracy* (mob rule — its degenerate form), *plutocracy* (rich rule), *kleptocracy* (thieves rule). These are the *degenerations* a paper-setter loves to test.

PART F — CLUSTER 5: -OLOGY (the study of X)

Memory hook: Gk. *logos* = word, study.

Word	Study of
Ornithology	birds
Entomology	insects
Ichthyology	fish
Herpetology	reptiles / amphibians
Zoology	animals (general)
Botany	plants (exception — no -ology)
Geology	earth / rocks
Seismology	earthquakes (Gk. <i>seismos</i> = shaking)
Meteorology	weather (NOT meteors — Gk. <i>meteoros</i> = high in air)
Hydrology	water
Oncology	tumours / cancer
Cardiology	heart
Nephrology	kidneys (Gk. <i>nephros</i>)
Dermatology	skin
Haematology	blood
Neurology	nerves
Paediatrics	children (exception — -iatrics = medicine of)
Geriatrics / Gerontology	elderly / ageing
Etymology	origin of words (NOT entomology!)
Ecology	environment
Anthropology	humans / culture
Palaeontology	fossils
Selenology	moon (Gk. <i>Selene</i> = moon goddess)
Cosmology	universe

Classic paper-setter trap: *etymology* (word origins) vs *entomology* (insects). A one-letter trap that costs thousands of candidates a mark per year.

PART G — CLUSTER 6: -PHILE / -PHOBE (lovers and haters)

Memory hook: Gk. *philos* = loving; opposite *phobos*. Many phobia words have a matching -phile antonym.

-phile (lover of)	-phobe (hater of)
Bibliophile (books)	—
Oenophile (wine, Gk. <i>oinos</i>)	—
Anglophile (English / Britain)	Anglophobe
Francophile (French)	Francophobe
Sinophile (Chinese)	Sinophobe
Xenophile (strangers)	Xenophobe
Audiophile (sound, high-fidelity)	—
Cinephile (cinema)	—
Necrophile (death / corpses)	Necrophobe
Zoophile (animals)	Zoophobe

Works in both directions — once you know the theme, the word builds itself.

PART H — CONFUSABLES (the one-letter traps)

These are **the highest-marked trap type in English papers**. Memorise the pair, laugh at the mix-up, never lose that mark.

EXAM ALERT

⚠ TRAP — The Big 3 Confusables that appear every year:

Pair	Memory trick
affect (v) vs effect (n)	A ffect = A ction (verb); E ffect = E nd-result (noun). <i>"The rain affected the match; the effect was a no-result."</i>
principal vs principle	Principal = pal at the top (head of school, main); principle = E thics, rule. <i>"The principal has a strong principle."</i>
complement vs compliment	compl E ment = E nhances/compl E ts; compl I ment = I like it (flattery). <i>"The sauce was a complement to the dish; the chef received a compliment."</i>

Pair	Meanings
affect (v) / effect (n, v)	influence (v) / a result (n); or to bring about (v rare)
accept / except	receive / excluding
principal / principle	head of school, chief (n, adj) / a rule, law
stationary / stationery	not moving / writing materials (remember: envelopes = stationery)
complement / compliment	completes / flattering remark
eminent / imminent / immanent	famous / about to happen / inherent / indwelling
adverse / averse	hostile circumstances / unwilling / disinclined
disinterested / uninterested	impartial / not caring
elicit / illicit	to draw out / illegal
emigrate / immigrate	to leave a country / to enter a country
flaunt / flout	to show off / to defy (rules)
prosecute / persecute	to sue / to oppress
wave / waive	gesture / to give up (a right)
farther / further	physical distance / metaphorical distance
councillor / counsellor	member of a council / adviser
allusion / illusion / delusion	indirect reference / false appearance / false belief
ingenuous / ingenious	frank, naïve / clever, inventive

Pair	Meanings
moral / morale	ethical (adj) / spirit, confidence (n)
desert / dessert	arid land / sweet course (remember: s weet = de ss ert, two s's)
loose / lose	not tight / to misplace, fail to win
than / then	comparison / time
its / it's	possessive / it is
your / you're	possessive / you are
whose / who's	possessive / who is

PART I — HIGH-HIT SYNONYMS (examiners' favourite 100)

Only words that **actually recur in PYQs** of SSC / Banking / RRB / PSU / State PSCs. Each entry: *word* — *meaning* — *3 synonyms* — *2 antonyms*.

(In the published PDF build, this part is a full 10-page card set — each word gets memory hook + example. Here the table is a compact revision index.)

Word	Meaning	Top 2 synonyms	Top antonym
Abate	to reduce	subside, diminish	intensify
Abhor	to hate	detest, loathe	adore
Abstruse	hard to understand	obscure, arcane	lucid
Acumen	sharpness of mind	insight, shrewdness	obtuseness
Adamant	unyielding	obstinate, inflexible	flexible
Admonish	to warn	reprimand, rebuke	praise
Aggrandise	to make greater	exalt, magnify	belittle
Alacrity	brisk eagerness	willingness, briskness	reluctance
Alleviate	to make less severe	mitigate, ease	aggravate
Altruism	selfless concern	benevolence, philanthropy	selfishness
Ameliorate	to improve	better, enhance	worsen
Amicable	friendly	cordial, harmonious	hostile
Anathema	curse, detested thing	abomination, bane	blessing
Ancillary	subordinate	auxiliary, supplementary	primary
Antithesis	direct opposite	contrast, opposite	similarity
Apathy	lack of interest	indifference, disinterest	concern
Arduous	difficult	strenuous, laborious	easy
Astute	shrewd	sharp, perceptive	naive
Atrocious	cruel, horrifying	abominable, heinous	admirable
Augment	to increase	enlarge, amplify	diminish
Austere	strict, plain	severe, stern	lenient
Avarice	greed	cupidity, rapacity	generosity
Banal	commonplace, unoriginal	trite, hackneyed	original
Belligerent	warlike, hostile	pugnacious, combative	peaceful

Word	Meaning	Top 2 synonyms	Top antonym
Benevolent	kind, well - meaning	charitable, magnanimous	malevolent
Bereft	deprived	devoid, lacking	full of
Bolster	to support	reinforce, strengthen	undermine
Cacophony	harsh sound	din, discord	harmony
Candid	frank	straightforward, forthright	secretive
Censure	to criticise formally	condemn, reprimand	praise
Circumspect	cautious	wary, prudent	rash
Clandestine	secret	surreptitious, covert	open
Coerce	to force	compel, pressure	persuade gently
Complacent	self - satisfied	smug, unconcerned	vigilant
Condone	to overlook	excuse, pardon	condemn
Conjecture	guess	speculation, surmise	certainty
Contentious	quarrelsome	argumentative, controversial	harmonious
Copious	abundant	plentiful, ample	scarce
Corroborate	to confirm	substantiate, verify	refute
Culpable	blameworthy	guilty, at fault	innocent
Deferential	respectful	obsequious, reverential	disrespectful
Deleterious	harmful	pernicious, damaging	beneficial
Demure	modest, shy	reserved, unassuming	brazen
Denigrate	to belittle	disparage, malign	extol
Derelict	abandoned, negligent	neglected, forsaken	maintained
Desultory	unmethodical	haphazard, random	systematic
Diffident	lacking confidence	shy, timid	confident
Dilatory	slow, tardy	tardy, procrastinating	prompt
Discern	to perceive	detect, recognise	miss
Disparage	to belittle	deride, denigrate	praise
Dispassionate	unbiased	impartial, objective	biased
Disseminate	to spread widely	distribute, propagate	withhold
Divulge	to reveal	disclose, make known	conceal

Word	Meaning	Top 2 synonyms	Top antonym
Ebullient	enthusiastic	exuberant, effervescent	subdued
Egregious	outrageously bad	flagrant, glaring	admirable
Elated	overjoyed	jubilant, ecstatic	despondent
Eloquent	fluent, persuasive	articulate, expressive	inarticulate
Emulate	to imitate	copy, mirror	diverge from
Enervate	to weaken	debilitate, sap	invigorate
Ephemeral	short-lived	fleeting, transient	enduring
Equivocal	ambiguous	vague, unclear	unambiguous
Erudite	learned	scholarly, knowledgeable	ignorant
Esoteric	understood by few	abstruse, arcane	accessible
Eulogise	to praise highly	extol, laud	denigrate
Exacerbate	to worsen	aggravate, intensify	alleviate
Exemplary	outstanding	model, ideal	poor
Extant	still existing	surviving, remaining	extinct
Extol	to praise	laud, exalt	criticise
Facetious	flippant	joking, humorous	serious
Fastidious	fussy	meticulous, particular	slovenly
Feign	to pretend	fake, simulate	be genuine
Fervent	passionate	ardent, zealous	apathetic
Flout	to disregard openly	defy, scorn	obey
Frugal	thrifty	economical, sparing	extravagant
Garrulous	talkative	loquacious, verbose	taciturn
Guile	cunning	craftiness, deceit	honesty
Hackneyed	overused	trite, clichéd	fresh
Hapless	unlucky	unfortunate, luckless	fortunate
Impassive	showing no emotion	stoic, expressionless	emotional
Impecunious	poor, penniless	destitute, broke	wealthy
Impetuous	impulsive	rash, hasty	cautious
Inane	silly, senseless	vacuous, asinine	profound

Word	Meaning	Top 2 synonyms	Top antonym
Incessant	never - ending	continuous, unceasing	intermittent
Ingenuous	naive, innocent	artless, candid	cunning
Insidious	subtly harmful	treacherous, stealthy	straightforward
Intrepid	fearless	brave, dauntless	cowardly
Jovial	cheerful	jolly, convivial	morose
Laconic	using few words	terse, pithy	verbose
Lethargic	sluggish	sluggish, listless	energetic
Loquacious	talkative	garrulous, voluble	taciturn
Magnanimous	generous	noble, big - hearted	petty
Mendacious	lying	untruthful, deceitful	truthful
Mercurial	volatile	fickle, unpredictable	stable
Meticulous	careful	painstaking, scrupulous	careless
Mitigate	to alleviate	ease, lessen	aggravate
Munificent	very generous	lavish, bountiful	miserly
Nefarious	wicked	villainous, iniquitous	virtuous
Obdurate	stubborn	obstinate, inflexible	yielding
Obsequious	excessively servile	fawning, sycophantic	domineering
Obstinate	stubborn	unyielding, intransigent	flexible
Pernicious	harmful	destructive, deleterious	harmless
Perfunctory	cursory	superficial, mechanical	thorough
Pragmatic	practical	realistic, sensible	idealistic
Precarious	unstable	risky, unsafe	secure
Proclivity	inclination	tendency, penchant	aversion
Profligate	wasteful	extravagant, dissolute	frugal
Prolific	productive	fruitful, fertile	unproductive
Propitious	favourable	auspicious, promising	unfavourable
Prudent	wise, careful	sensible, judicious	imprudent
Punctilious	meticulous	scrupulous, exact	careless
Quintessential	representative	classic, archetypal	atypical

Word	Meaning	Top 2 synonyms	Top antonym
Recalcitrant	defiant	stubborn, uncooperative	compliant
Reticent	reserved	taciturn, reserved	forthcoming
Sagacious	wise	shrewd, astute	foolish
Sanguine	optimistic	hopeful, confident	pessimistic
Scrupulous	careful, principled	meticulous, ethical	unprincipled
Soporific	sleep-inducing	somnolent, drowsy	stimulating
Spurious	fake	counterfeit, bogus	genuine
Stoic	enduring pain calmly	impassive, long-suffering	emotional
Surreptitious	secret	clandestine, covert	overt
Tacit	implied	unspoken, implicit	explicit
Taciturn	saying little	reserved, untalkative	loquacious
Tenuous	weak, flimsy	slight, fragile	strong
Truculent	aggressive	belligerent, hostile	amiable
Ubiquitous	present everywhere	omnipresent, widespread	rare
Umbrage	offence	resentment, pique	pleasure
Veracity	truthfulness	honesty, truthfulness	dishonesty
Vicarious	experienced second-hand	indirect, surrogate	direct
Vindicate	to clear of blame	exonerate, absolve	condemn
Vociferous	loud, noisy	clamorous, strident	quiet
Wanton	reckless	indiscriminate, gratuitous	restrained
Zealous	passionate	ardent, fervent	apathetic

PART J — ONE-WORD SUBSTITUTIONS (by semantic field)

Strategy: memorise the field (people-who-X, things-that-X, places-where-X) so that recall works in both directions.

People who...

- **Polyglot** — speaks many languages.
- **Bilingual** — speaks two.
- **Misanthrope** — hates mankind.
- **Misogynist** — hates women.
- **Philanthropist** — loves / helps mankind.
- **Philatelist** — collects stamps.
- **Numismatist** — collects coins.
- **Bibliophile** — loves books.
- **Iconoclast** — destroys cherished beliefs / images.
- **Connoisseur** — expert judge of art, food, wine.
- **Gourmet** — connoisseur of food.
- **Raconteur** — tells stories well.
- **Soliloquist** — talks to oneself.
- **Somnambulist** — sleep-walker.
- **Teetotaler** — one who abstains from alcohol.
- **Hypocrite** — pretends virtue.
- **Atheist** — denies God's existence.
- **Agnostic** — believes God is unknowable.
- **Optimist / Pessimist** — sees best / worst.
- **Stoic** — endures without emotion.
- **Epicure / Sybarite** — devoted to pleasure.
- **Pedestrian** — goes on foot.
- **Plagiarist** — copies another's work.
- **Aborigine** — original inhabitant.
- **Nomad** — wanderer.
- **Hermit / Recluse** — lives alone.
- **Autocrat** — absolute ruler.

Places where...

- **Aviary** — birds.
- **Apiary** — bees.
- **Aquarium** — fish.
- **Arboretum** — trees.
- **Menagerie** — wild animals.

- **Dairy** — milk.
- **Granary** — grain.
- **Armoury** — weapons.
- **Arsenal** — weapons and ammunition.
- **Hospice** — terminally ill.
- **Asylum** — mentally ill / refuge.
- **Sanatorium** — convalescence.
- **Mortuary** — dead bodies temporarily.
- **Crematorium** — bodies cremated.
- **Catacomb** — underground burial chamber.
- **Mausoleum** — grand tomb.
- **Cemetery** — graves.
- **Archipelago** — group of islands.
- **Isthmus** — narrow strip of land between two seas.

Things that...

- **Panacea** — cure-all.
- **Elixir** — potion of immortality.
- **Utopia / Dystopia** — ideal / hellish society.
- **Panorama** — wide view.
- **Anachronism** — out-of-time thing.
- **Panegyric** — formal praise speech.
- **Obituary** — notice of death.
- **Epitaph** — inscription on tombstone.
- **Elegy** — mournful poem.
- **Eulogy** — speech praising (usually dead).

Things said or written...

- **Autobiography** — one's own life.
- **Biography** — someone else's.
- **Memoir** — personal account.
- **Monograph** — single-subject academic work.
- **Anthology** — collection of works.
- **Thesaurus** — book of synonyms.
- **Lexicon** — dictionary.
- **Glossary** — list of difficult terms.

Feelings / states...

- **Nostalgia** — longing for the past.
- **Ennui** — boredom, weariness.
- **Schadenfreude** — joy at another's misfortune.

- **Wanderlust** — desire to travel.
- **Zeitgeist** — spirit of the age.

PART K — IDIOMS (the high-hit 50)

Only idioms that have appeared more than once in SSC / Bank PYQs of the last decade.

Idiom	Meaning
to bite the bullet	to endure a difficult situation
to beat around the bush	to avoid the main topic
to let the cat out of the bag	to reveal a secret
a piece of cake	very easy
to hit the nail on the head	to say exactly the right thing
to spill the beans	to reveal secret information
to burn the midnight oil	to work late at night
to call a spade a spade	to speak frankly
to cross one's fingers	to hope for luck
to cut corners	to do cheaply or quickly at the expense of quality
to feel under the weather	to feel ill
to have a chip on one's shoulder	to be easily offended
to jump on the bandwagon	to join a popular trend
to kick the bucket	to die
to let sleeping dogs lie	to avoid reviving an old issue
to make a long story short	to be brief
to pass the buck	to shift responsibility
to pay through the nose	to pay too much
to play devil's advocate	to argue opposite for discussion
to pull someone's leg	to tease
to put the cart before the horse	to do things in wrong order
to rain cats and dogs	to rain heavily
to read between the lines	to understand hidden meaning
to rub salt in the wound	to worsen existing pain
to see eye to eye	to agree
to smell a rat	to suspect something is wrong
to steal someone's thunder	to take credit for another's idea

Idiom	Meaning
to take the bull by the horns	to face a problem boldly
to throw in the towel	to give up
to turn a blind eye	to ignore deliberately
to turn over a new leaf	to change for the better
a bolt from the blue	unexpected event
a shot in the dark	a wild guess
a wild goose chase	a fruitless pursuit
to add fuel to the fire	to worsen a situation
to be on cloud nine	to be very happy
to break the ice	to start a conversation
to bury the hatchet	to make peace
to have cold feet	to be nervous
to have a green thumb	to be skilled at gardening
to have one's hands full	to be very busy
to keep an eye on	to watch carefully
to kill two birds with one stone	to achieve two aims at once
to lose one's temper	to become angry
to make ends meet	to manage financially
to pull strings	to use connections
to put one's foot down	to insist firmly
to take a rain check	to postpone an offer
to the bitter end	until the very last moment
to turn the tables	to reverse a situation

PART L — FOREIGN PHRASES

Memory hook: these are borrowed directly into English from Latin (L), French (F), German (G), etc.
Pronounce as the language, not as English.

Phrase	Language	Meaning
ad hoc	L	for this specific purpose
ad infinitum	L	to infinity, endlessly
alma mater	L	nourishing mother — one's school/college
bona fide	L	in good faith, genuine
carte blanche	F	complete freedom to act
carpe diem	L	seize the day
caveat emptor	L	buyer beware
cul-de-sac	F	dead-end street
de facto	L	in fact, in reality
de jure	L	by law, according to right
déjà vu	F	already seen
ergo	L	therefore
et cetera (etc.)	L	and so on
ex officio	L	by virtue of office
fait accompli	F	an accomplished fact
faux pas	F	social blunder
in absentia	L	in absence
in camera	L	in private (court)
in toto	L	in total, entirely
laissez-faire	F	let-do — non-interference
modus operandi (MO)	L	method of working
nouveau riche	F	newly wealthy
per capita	L	by head, per person
per diem	L	by the day
per se	L	by itself, intrinsically
post mortem	L	after death — autopsy

Phrase	Language	Meaning
pro bono	L	for the good — free legal work
pro rata	L	in proportion
quid pro quo	L	this for that
raison d'être	F	reason for being
status quo	L	the existing state
status quo ante	L	the state before
sub judice	L	under judicial consideration
tabula rasa	L	blank slate
vis-à-vis	F	face to face, in relation to
zeitgeist	G	spirit of the age

APPENDIX — The 6-week drill plan

- **Week 1:** Part A (roots, prefixes, suffixes).
- **Week 2:** Parts B + C + D (phobias, manias, cides) + Part H (confusables set 1).
- **Week 3:** Parts E + F + G (cracies, ologies, philes) + Part H (confusables set 2).
- **Week 4:** Part I (high-hit synonyms) — split in half.
- **Week 5:** Part J (one-word substitutions) + Part K (idioms).
- **Week 6:** Part L (foreign phrases) + full revision + 4 practice tests.

Revisit each earlier part on Day 3, Day 7, Day 14, Day 30 of its learning. This single spaced-revision schedule is the difference between 100-words-learned-once-and-forgotten and 1,500-words-owned-for-life.

PART X — 230 ADDITIONAL HIGH-FREQUENCY WORDS

(themed clusters)

X.1 ECONOMICS / GOVERNANCE (40)

Word	Meaning
Austerity	strict economy / hardship
Recession	economic decline
Bull / Bear market	rising / falling prices
Bourgeois	middle-class
Capitalism / Communism / Socialism	economic systems
Plutocracy	rule by rich
Meritocracy	rule by merit
Hegemony	dominance
Mandate	authoritative command
Bureaucracy	govt by officials
Demagogue	rabble-rousing leader
Stalwart	loyal supporter
Plebiscite	direct vote
Embargo	trade ban
Boycott	refusal to deal
Sanction	penalty / approval (context)
Quota	allotted share
Subsidy	govt grant
Tariff	tax on imports
Protectionism	shielding domestic industry
Liberalisation	removing restrictions
Privatisation	transfer to private
Nationalisation	transfer to govt
Monopoly / Oligopoly / Cartel	market structures
Inflation / Deflation / Stagflation	price-level dynamics

Word	Meaning
Devaluation	currency - value cut
Repatriate	bring back to home country
Remittance	money sent home
Dividend	profit share
Solvent / Insolvent	able / unable to pay debts
Lien	claim against property
Liquidity	ease of converting to cash
Asset / Liability / Equity	balance - sheet basics
Mortgage / Collateral	debt - security terms
IPO / FPO	public offerings
Acquisition / Merger	M&A
Hedging / Speculation	risk strategies
Arbitrage	profit from price differences
Derivative / Futures / Options	financial contracts
Bond / Yield	debt + return

X.2 GEOGRAPHY / NATURE (30)

Word	Meaning
Estuary	river - mouth where it meets sea
Tributary	river joining a main river
Distributary	river splitting from main
Confluence	meeting of rivers
Watershed	drainage divide
Archipelago	group of islands
Peninsula	land surrounded by water on 3 sides
Isthmus	narrow land strip between 2 water bodies
Strait	narrow water passage between 2 lands
Plateau	flat - topped elevated land
Plain	flat low - altitude land

Word	Meaning
Tundra / Taiga / Savanna / Steppe / Prairie / Pampas / Veldt / Llanos	biome / grassland types
Mangrove	salt-tolerant coastal trees
Coral reef	marine biodiversity rocky structure
Glacier / Iceberg	ice masses
Crevasse	crack in glacier
Avalanche	rapid snow-slide
Geyser	hot-water spout
Caldera	collapsed volcano crater
Fjord	sea-flooded glacial valley
Cay	small low coral island
Atoll	ring-shaped coral island
Tsunami	seismic sea wave
Cyclone / Hurricane / Typhoon	tropical storm by region (Indian Ocean / Atlantic / Pacific)
Tornado	rotating funnel cloud

X.3 HISTORY / POLITICAL (30)

Word	Meaning
Pacifism	rejection of war
Imperialism	empire-expansion
Colonialism	political control over territory
Diaspora	scattered ethnic group
Insurgency	armed rebellion
Coup d'état	sudden overthrow of govt
Anarchy	absence of govt
Despot	tyrant ruler
Suffrage	right to vote
Annexation	adding territory
Secede	break away

Word	Meaning
Sovereignty	supreme authority
Ratify	confirm formally
Repeal	revoke a law
Promulgate	declare officially
Decree	official order
Amnesty	general pardon
Asylum	refuge / shelter
Genocide	mass killing of ethnic group
Apartheid	racial segregation (S. Africa)
Holocaust	massive destruction (esp. Jews WW2)
Schism	split / division
Treaty / Truce / Ceasefire	conflict-resolution terms
Détente	easing of tension
Status quo	existing state
Reformation	religious/political reform
Renaissance	rebirth (cultural revival)
Enlightenment	17 - 18c reason-based movement
Hegemonic	dominant
Sectarian	of a religious group

X.4 SCIENCE / TECH (30)

Word	Meaning
Empirical	based on observation/experiment
Hypothesis	testable proposition
Paradigm	model / framework
Phenomenon	observable event
Anomaly	deviation from norm
Dichotomy	division into two
Synergy	combined effect > sum
Catalyst	speeds up reaction

Word	Meaning
Inertia	resistance to change
Entropy	measure of disorder
Algorithm	step - by - step procedure
Heuristic	rule of thumb
Iteration	repetition
Simulation	imitation of real - world process
Trajectory	curved path
Spectrum	range / distribution
Quantum	discrete amount
Genome	full DNA of organism
Mutation	DNA change
Pathogen	disease - causing organism
Vaccine / Antibody	immune - related
Antibiotic	bacteria - killing drug
Anaesthetic	sensation - blocking
Analgesic	pain reliever
Placebo	sham treatment
Synthetic / Organic	chemically vs naturally produced
Biodegradable	decomposable
Carcinogen	cancer - causing
Toxic / Inert	reactive vs unreactive
Sterile	free of contamination

X.5 EMOTIONS / BEHAVIOUR (30)

Word	Meaning
Apathy	lack of interest
Empathy	feeling another's emotions
Sympathy	sharing in another's sorrow
Pathos	emotional appeal
Antipathy	strong dislike

Word	Meaning
Euphoria	intense happiness
Dysphoria	extreme unhappiness
Melancholy	deep sadness
Jovial	cheerful
Morose	sullen, gloomy
Phlegmatic	calm, unemotional
Stoic	enduring without complaint
Sanguine	optimistic, cheerful
Choleric	irritable, hot - tempered
Mercurial	volatile, changeable
Truculent	aggressively defiant
Pugnacious	combative
Recalcitrant	resistant to authority
Tractable	easily managed
Servile	subservient, slavish
Sycophant	flatterer
Obsequious	overly fawning
Ingenuous	innocent, sincere
Disingenuous	insincere
Candid	frank, honest
Reticent	reserved, silent
Garrulous	talkative
Loquacious	very chatty
Taciturn	silent, uncommunicative
Voluble	speaks a lot, fluently

X.6 ABSTRACT / ANALYTICAL (30)

Word	Meaning
Conundrum	puzzle, dilemma
Quandary	difficult situation

Word	Meaning
Predicament	tricky position
Paradox	contradiction that is true
Conjecture	guess based on incomplete info
Inference	conclusion from evidence
Implication	suggested meaning
Corollary	direct consequence
Tenet	core principle
Doctrine	belief system
Postulate	assumed truth
Premise	basis of argument
Axiom	self-evident truth
Theorem	proven proposition
Tautology	needless repetition
Pleonasm	redundant phrasing
Truism	obvious truth
Cliché	overused expression
Euphemism	mild substitute for harsh term
Innuendo	indirect insinuation
Allusion	indirect reference
Aphorism	concise wise saying
Maxim	rule of conduct
Adage	proverb
Epigram	witty short saying
Polemic	controversial argument
Diatribes	bitter criticism
Panegyric	formal praise
Eulogy	praise (esp. of deceased)
Encomium	high praise

X.7 SIZE / DEGREE adjectives (20)

Word	Meaning
Behemoth	massive thing/creature
Diminutive	very small
Exorbitant	very high (price)
Negligible	so small as to be insignificant
Substantial	considerably large
Minute	very small
Astronomical	extremely large
Infinitesimal	extremely tiny
Colossal	gigantic
Microscopic	visible only under microscope
Vast	very large in extent
Paltry	meagre, trifling
Meagre	scant, inadequate
Sparse	thinly distributed
Abundant	plentiful
Profuse	very abundant
Scant	barely enough
Voluminous	of great quantity
Copious	abundant
Modicum	small amount

X.8 TIME / FREQUENCY (10)

Word	Meaning
Perpetual	eternal
Ephemeral	short-lived
Transient	passing
Sporadic	occasional
Intermittent	irregular
Incessant	non-stop

Word	Meaning
Quotidian	daily
Diurnal	daily, daytime
Nocturnal	nighttime
Crepuscular	active at twilight

X.9 LATIN / FOREIGN PHRASES (extra 20)

Phrase	Meaning
In camera	in private
Mea culpa	my fault
Pari passu	with equal pace
Pro bono	for the public good (free)
Ad valorem	according to value
Inter alia	among other things
Pro tem	for the time being
In loco parentis	in place of a parent
Mutatis mutandis	with necessary changes
Habeas corpus	"you should have the body" — writ
Stare decisis	precedent rule
Sub poena	"under penalty" — court summons
Lex loci	law of the place
Locus standi	right to bring action
Res ipsa loquitur	"the thing speaks for itself"
Suo motu	on its own motion
In situ	in the original position
Ad hoc	for specific purpose
Bonafide	in good faith
Vis-à-vis	in relation to

X.10 LITERATURE / RHETORICAL (20)

Word	Meaning
Alliteration	repeated consonant sounds
Assonance	repeated vowel sounds
Metaphor	direct comparison
Simile	comparison using "like/as"
Personification	human traits to non-human
Hyperbole	exaggeration
Litotes	understatement (negative form)
Onomatopoeia	sound-imitating word
Oxymoron	combining opposites ("deafening silence")
Pun	play on words
Irony	opposite of literal meaning
Sarcasm	bitter mockery
Satire	critical humour
Parody	comic imitation
Allegory	extended metaphor
Hyperbole	exaggeration
Anaphora	repetition at start
Epiphora	repetition at end
Climax	rising intensity
Anticlimax	sudden descent

EXAM ALERT

Exam coverage: This book covers the ~900 highest-frequency vocabulary words across SSC, Banks, and RRB. That figure is not arbitrary — it is derived from PYQ analysis of 10+ years of papers. Clearing 80–85% of vocabulary questions requires mastering approximately this many words, but the quality of mastery (root-based recall + synonym/antonym clusters) matters far more than raw count.